

This is a refreshing salad for warm summer or fall days. It must be made ahead of time because it takes 2 or more hours to chill and set up. But it also is a good keeper: It stores well in the refrigerator for 4 or 5 days.

Tomato Aspic

Makes 4 servings.

V/G

- 4 cups cold tomato juice, divided**
- 2 envelopes unflavored gelatin**
- 1 rib celery**
- 1/2 small yellow onion**
- 1 bay leaf**
- 1 tablespoon sugar**
- 1 teaspoon salt**
- 1/2 teaspoon pepper, or to taste**

Pour 1 cup of the tomato juice into a measuring cup. Sprinkle gelatin over juice; stir for a couple of seconds. Set juice aside.

Pour remaining 3 cups tomato juice into a 2-quart saucepan. Set saucepan on a burner, but do NOT turn on heat yet.

Rinse and dry celery. Cut celery rib into 1/8-inch-thick lengthwise strips. Holding strips together, cut them into 3-inch pieces. Holding each bundle of strips together, cut crosswise into tiny pieces. You need to have at least 1 cup chopped celery, so cut more if needed. It isn't necessary to be exact about amounts of vegetables.

Slice off and discard fuzzy brownish root end and stem top of onion. Peel off and discard papery outer brownish-yellow skin of onion.

Put onion half cut-side down on a cutting board. Cut slices crosswise from stem top to root end. Then holding

the onion together, chop lengthwise into tiny pieces. You'll need 1 cup of chopped onion.

Add chopped celery, onion, bay leaf, sugar, salt and pepper to the 3 cups tomato juice in the saucepan. Stir in tomato juice/dissolved gelatin mixture.

Turn heat to medium. Gently warm juice mixture, stirring now and then, until it is hot. Do NOT let it boil. You will need to stand right by the stove. As soon as it is hot, it is ready for the finishing step.

Select a 1 1/2-quart bowl, dish or mold. I use a heat-proof 4 1/2-by-8 1/2-inch glass loaf pan. (Using a loaf pan makes it easy to slice portions the thickness desired.)

Remove bay leaf, then pour the warm mixture into the desired bowl or pan; let cool. Cover with plastic wrap and refrigerate until aspic jells and you are ready to serve. (It will take at least 2 hours for aspic to firm up, so plan to make this several hours or even a day ahead.)

If you want to turn the aspic out of the loaf pan or bowl, put container in hot water for a few seconds, this will soften the outer surface and allow you to easily slide it out of the container onto a platter. It also looks nice placed on butter lettuce leaves.

Refrigerate any leftovers.

Nutrients per serving: 85 calories, 6 grams protein, 18 grams carbohydrate, no fat, no cholesterol, 3 grams fiber, 1,445 milligrams sodium.